

Humans 2.0?

AS SOMEONE whose job revolves around technology, I spend more time in front of a screen than anyone I know (outside of the Digit team). I'm far from healthy, get almost no exercise, and yet I'm part of a norm these days instead of the exception, when it comes to the average city dweller across the globe. I've watched all the talks given by experts, and been scared witless by their proclamations. As I sit shivering in fear in front of my PC with two large monitors showing me up to four windows at a time, I reach for a bag of chips – hey, I'm scared about my health... I need comfort, and chips are like a big hug in a bag!

Oh well, I'll take my mind of it by playing a game, and then a few conference calls and hangouts later, I'm back to reading on my PC in my super comfy gaming chair. Not just any chair, but one with excellent lumbar support, because although I may die of vascular disease or diabetes or something, at least I'll avoid lower back pain!

If there's one thing that everyone criticises about technology, it's the way it's making us lethargic and inactive, and fat, and unhealthy, and killing us... but do we care? Heck no!

For example, I developed a severe case of text claw (a severe pain in my left wrist caused from too much phone usage), and all I had to do was walk into a general chemist store here in Australia, and tell them about it, they nod their heads knowingly, empathising with me, even saying, "Oh, we've all been there hun!" and then they measure my hand and give me a perfectly sized support glove with a metal bar in it that's designed to keep my wrist from bending. Problem solved! Or is it?

Thanks to technology, our lives are going to become easier as we shift to more creative and thoughtful work. Doing things that computers can't (yet), and letting robots and AI take over "menial" jobs. Humans have stopped evolving naturally, according to Michio Kaku, David Attenborough and others.

Some scientists believe we're not evolving at all, especially if natural selection is the only method of evolution, because we've overcome natural selection, and the pressures of our environment. They consider it all to be artificial selection now, or basically more of a cultural evolution that's driven more by human society than by nature. Others disagree, saying that all of this is part of natural selection. Just as dinosaurs

ruled the earth once, humans rule it currently, but there's no reason to assume that we will always... it could just take one asteroid to wipe the slate clean. I'm on the fence a little. I don't think it's either one, but both in fact. Our long term evolution might in fact still be natural selection, but our short term evolution certainly is artificial (or basically of our own doing).

Technology is no different than, say, some small flightless dinosaur developing feathers or flaps and then eventually using that to its advantage, and then later generations perfecting it and developing the ability to fly. Of course it is still somewhat artificial selection, because while natural selection takes a long time, technology enabled artificial selection is acting at unheard of speeds and changing us far faster than we have thought.

And no, I don't mean just making us fat and lazy. I mean technology is involved in many good things too, such as giving us bionic appendages that are actually stronger than our original flesh-based ones. Bionics certainly seems to be the way forward, and the stage is set for such products to exit the category of "disabled", and enter the mainstream.

For example, companies are researching and have developed prototypes of hearing aids that can give you superhuman hearing, allowing you to focus on what people across a room are whispering about by cutting out the rest of the room noise! Search for "Phonak" to see some of the stuff being done with hearing aids. Plenty of startups have come and gone in the space, but they may have been a tad before their time. Apple has tied up with Cochlear to design hearing aids or implants that will talk directly to the user's iPhone, but it's not the first (as usual). Plenty of products already exist that use Bluetooth and allow your hearing aids to connect to TVs, phones, etc. It's not just about hearing someone's voice anymore, and it's not just about the disabled... and that's just what's changing in the field of hearing!

At the rate we're going, it will be just a few hundred years before we morph into something that we would consider unrecognisable. If space travel ever gets going, we might morph even more drastically as a species, and that will still always be a good thing. If you'd like to read more about the future of humans, we could do a more indepth article. Write in and tell me if you want us to do that. [d](#)



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